



MAMATA ADDRESSES
TRINAMOOL WORKERS

SUBASHISH MULLICK

Kolkata—says its own story. And, of course, Singur, Nandigram and Mamata's one-point programme that the Buddhadeb Bhattacharya Government was out to grab the land from the poor also helped. Significantly, the Left's main plank of agrarian reforms has been totally usurped by Mamata. Also harping on the fact that the BJP was a communal party, she successfully wooed the Muslims who voted en-bloc for her. **by Abhijit Dasgupta**

LALU & PASWAN

Troubled Double

The writing was on the wall but Lalu and Paswan preferred to howl and scowl at everyone, including the Congress. The two had reasons to trust their instincts. In 1999, when Paswan was with the NDA, the alliance swept the polls in Bihar. In 2004 when the LJP chief joined hands with RJD, it benefited the RJD combine in a big way. Still, sometimes the best laid plans go awry. And as it finally turned out, the voters in Bihar betrayed a mood that was more hurting and even more dismissive than what perhaps the two had imagined. Along with their political fortunes, even their reputation as politi-

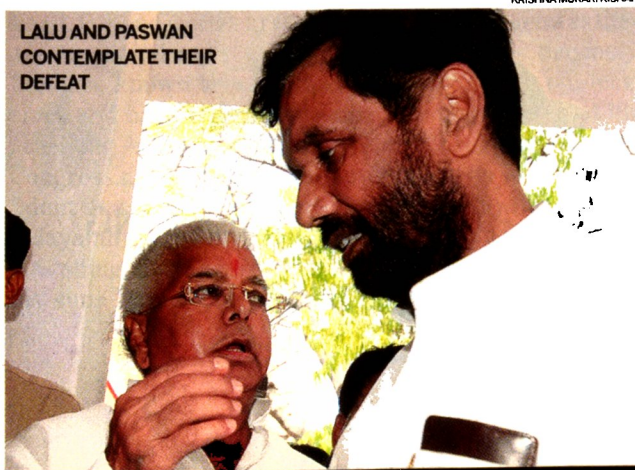
cians with an ear to the ground was in tatters. Worse still, while Paswan lost from Hajipur, which was known as his pocket borough, RJD chief Lalu too lost from Patliputra, although he somewhat salvaged his reputation by winning the Saran seat. Paswan's brother Ramchandra Paswan also lost from Samastipur. In fact, Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party, that had four MPs in the 14th Lok Sabha, could not win a single seat. During their brief interaction with the media on May 16, both agreed that leaving the Congress alone was a political mistake.

Though Paswan maintained that he would try to revive his party in Bihar, Lalu—despite his *"Opposition mein baithenge"* avowal—appeared eager to join the UPA Government by suggesting that he was with Mulayam Singh Yadav. "The next step is to discuss the future course of action with Mulayam Singh. We will then decide. It is for the Congress to decide if they need our help," he said.

The reason for the crushing defeat, however, is not difficult to assess. Many believe, even within the RJD-LJP combine, that Lalu concentrated too much on the caste and secularism factors, alienating the new Bihar voter, who has a fresh set of priorities like law and order and employment. The results also show that the duo's aim of unifying the lower castes and classes—rallying the Yadavs, holding on to its support base among the Muslims and adding a substantial section of Dalits—failed to materialise. Much of Lalu-Paswan's chagrin about caste and secular theories cuts little ice with the common citizen.

A senior RJD leader conceded that both the leaders now need to start from scratch. "Introspection is called for. We have to consider if the path we were following was the right one. Assembly polls are just 16 months away and ironically we are slipping behind," he said. In fact, assembly polls is perhaps the only reason that will keep both Paswan and Lalu together. With their backs to the wall, the two leaders who are known for their stubborn determination will surely fight to stay afloat.

by Amitabh Srivastava



LALU AND PASWAN
CONTEMPLATE THEIR
DEFEAT

KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN